The Visitors In The Darkness

Tara had been only six years old. *Ajji* had left Tara alone for a few hours in the cottage, as she needed to go to the market to buy some essential goods. Tara was happy to have the whole house to herself. For the first time ever, she had no one to watch over her.

Tara jumped around like crazy and yelled,

"I'm free. I can do whatever I want!"

She sneaked...well walked into the kitchen happily to grab a few pieces of *Kajjaya**, that her granny had stored in a jar. Kajjaya were kept only for special occasions and Tara often sneaked into the kitchen to eat some.

Tara stuffed her mouth, placed a few pieces in the folds of her skirt, and went to the gardens. Leela and Sheela, who were often free, were jingling their bells nearby. She quickly finished eating and started playing.

She set up a shop to sell her clay toy pots, where Moti was the first customer. While he was checking their quality by smelling and licking them, Chiku, the next customer, bought three pots and one pan without even having a look!

“Oh, Chiku and Moti, you’re such good friends, you bought all my wares, Now, I can buy my favorite doll with all this money. Tara had always wanted to have a doll however, *Ajji* couldn’t afford one. Tara wanted to help *Ajji* save up enough to buy the doll at the village fair.

A shriek from the forest distracted Tara. She climbed over the fence to look at the towering forest. It was as though inviting her to come to it. She imagined what unknown creatures could be in there!

Chiku flew up and perched on the fence next to her, almost making her fall. “Are you planning to go into the forest? Well then, count me out! I know for sure, there are ghosts, witches and monsters in there! If not, I am sure there are huge animals who can gobble us up in one go. I would never think of going there!”

Tara replied, “Well, I am not planning on going there today! But I will go there someday!” The sun had begun to set. They went inside the cottage and Tara lit the lamp, waiting for *Ajji.* As it got

darker, she felt lonely and couldn't help but remember the scary stories that *Ajji* had told her.

Tara felt hungry, tired, and sleepy. Tara, Moti, and Chiku snuggled up in their bed and waited for *Ajji* to return. Tara began to think of all the possible reasons that could have made *Ajji* late. Had she been stuck on the way? They used to be back by this time every day when they went together, so where was she! What had happened?

Tara walked up to the window and saw that it was about to rain. She lit another lamp hanging from the pole in the cottage and turned the knob to make it brighter.

"What is making her so late?" wondered Chiku. "What if she lost her way? Or some thieves caught her? Or worse, what if Kalika, the witch, caught her? I am scared, Tara.

Suddenly, there was a knocking on the door. "Don't open the door, Tara. I'm sure it's *Kalika*. She knows we are alone," said Chiku.

"Tara, Putta, open the door. It's me, *Ajji.*" Tara hesitated as *Ajji* had warned her not to open the door for strangers. "Who is it?" "It's me, Tara! *Ajji!* Why do you ask?" Tara peeped through the window and saw that it was *Ajji* standing at the front door. She opened the door immediately and hugged her. "What took you so long, *Ajji?*"